

Practice Quiz 08A — MATH 2055 — Fall 2026 — Solutions

Practice for Quiz 08

Transitivity and equivalence classes of congruence.

Recall that $u \equiv v \pmod{3}$ means $3 \mid (u - v)$.

1. Define a relation on $\mathbf{Z}$ by $x \sim y$ if and only if $x \equiv y \pmod{3}$.

(a) Prove directly from the definition that $\sim$ is transitive.

Solution Let $x, y, z \in \mathbf{Z}$ and suppose $x \sim y$ and $y \sim z$. Then $3 \mid (x - y)$ and $3 \mid (y - z)$, so there are integers j, k such that

$$x - y = 3j \quad \text{and} \quad y - z = 3k.$$

Adding gives

$$x - z = (x - y) + (y - z) = 3(j + k).$$

Because $j + k$ is an integer, $3 \mid (x - z)$. Hence $x \equiv z \pmod{3}$, so $x \sim z$. Therefore $\sim$ is transitive. ■

(b) Assume that $\sim$ is also reflexive and symmetric. How many equivalence classes are there? List them.

Solution There are exactly 3 classes:

$$[0], [1], [2].$$

More explicitly, for each listed representative r ,

$$[r] = \{x \in \mathbf{Z} : x \equiv r \pmod{3}\}.$$

Every integer has exactly one remainder among the listed representatives, so these are all the classes and no two of them are equal. ■